

## BOOK REVIEWS

**DIMENSIONS OF ETERNAL LOVE****By William Huntington S.S.****ISBN 1 870223 27 6****Focus Christian Ministries Trust, Lewes****vi + 63 pages; £3.95**

In an age when Arminianist "free-offerist" fantasies have penetrated the body Calvinistic to a degree unprecedented, anything written by William Huntington (1745 - 1813 ) is bound to be dynamite. Slandered in his day as Hyper-Calvinist and as an Antinomian, Huntington has been largely forgotten by the generations succeeding him, and even now, 180 years after his death, when his name is brought up from the mists of forgettery, it is targeted for largely negative and even vituperative criticism. Such criticisms have been manifest in recent months in some popular evangelical and Calvinist journals. It is, however, quite instructive and enlightening, not to say, surprising, to read the man's work directly for one's self, instead of simply swallowing the criticisms made of him by some of today's "opinion-formers". One can then intelligently form his own opinion.

To this end, Focus Christian Ministries have produced this fine little book containing two of Huntington's writings, "The Dimensions of Eternal Love", and "The Final Exhortation", this latter being Huntington's "last blast of the trumpet" as it were, prior to his death. It is the first-mentioned sermon that fills most of this volume, and it was, of course, written in Huntington's true style.....he preached it first, extemporarily, then, some time afterwards, wrote it down, expanding it with multitudinous ramifications and extensions that came to him as he did so. No doubt, for ordinary mortals, Huntington's mode of sermonizing would be out of the question, indeed a seminary student would find himself reprimanded for such an approach ! But Huntington was, well, he was Huntington, and with him the method worked superbly ! The man must have been a walking talking concordance-cum-encyclopaedia of Scripture, and "Dimensions of Eternal Love" exemplifies his amazing faculty in this respect.

Taking Eph. 3 : 18-19 as his text, Huntington expounds the breadth, length, depth, and height of the love of Christ. His approach to this is really quaint and simple, he speaks of the "length" of Christ's love, for instance, as in terms of time, that it began in eternity, stretches through all the reaches of time, and then goes on into the measureless infinities of time to come.....eternal love. All the ramifications of this for God's elect people are then brought out, the expositions are a delight to read ! In similar quaint style, he goes on to examine the other

dimensions, adumbrating how the “breadth” of God’s love extends over His Elect, a people that expanded from the small beginnings with the line of Seth, then through Noah, Abraham, and ultimately to encompass some of every tribe and nation. A love that is indeed, discriminating in its breadth, reprobates are excluded from its aegis. In the “internationalization” of the church under the Apostolic gospel, Huntington draws attention astutely to Peter’s vision of the great sheet lowered from heaven with all the unclean beasts in it. The exposition here is most illuminating as he explains the spiritual typography manifest in that vision. The material given here was new to me, and I was amazed to see how Huntington could bring out insights into scripture here that I had not hitherto encountered, and all of it thoroughly supported by Scripture itself.

In the application made from this exposition, Huntington shows what must have made him so popular with the masses of his hearers. He certainly was a “soul doctor” and adept at applying the spiritual truths embodied in a text to the healing of spiritual wounds in the souls of poor sinners. His ministry, whatever critics may say of it, and whatever faults may have attended him in various ways, ( and no man is perfect, and that includes Huntington’s critics), was eminently appreciated over a wide realm, from working-class to even the King..

The second of the two works reprinted here, “The Final Exhortation”, based on Revelation 3 : 3 is taken from notes made by a hearer during the last sermon Huntington preached, and hence is in outline, rather than the full expansion that the preacher would have made himself. It is nevertheless an edifying piece of work, though I found his usage of the letters to the 7 Churches to be somewhat lacking in foundation when he applied them to 7 periods of Church History. But notwithstanding this, the material contained herein is most apposite to us today. Contrary to those critics who would persist in styling Huntington as an Antinomian, we find here “Watch, first *against sin*, that it does not get the upper hand of us and prove our master...” and “it is through the Spirit” that we “do mortify the deeds of the body” (Rom. 8 : 13 ). And again, he warns that we should “watch *against errors and heresy*”, and to “*watch the hand of God in His providences towards you*”, and to “*watch unto prayer*”. Finally, “*to watch your frames and feelings...*”

Amongst all this is found Huntington’s prophetic warnings concerning the revival of Romanism, and the opening floodgates of infidelity that threatened from within Protestantism. His words ring all too ominously true. Whatever modern critics may say about his “prophetic insight”, it has come true, all too true !

Focus Christian Ministries have presented this excellent little volume in high quality format. I found the exposition very satisfying to the soul, and a delight to read. I found myself reading a paragraph, and then spending upwards of twenty minutes meditating on all the ramifications of what I had just read. Truly, a profound little book, one to come back to, again, and again !

*Editor.*

**REVIVAL AND REVIVALISM**  
**The Making and Marring of**  
**American Evangelicalism; 1750 - 1858**  
 by **Iain H. Murray**

Edinburgh : THE BANNER OF TRUTH TRUST 1994

Hardback : xxii + 455 pages, £12.95

*Reviewed by Tony Horne*

Ever since the first issue of the Banner of Truth magazine appeared in September 1955, Iain Murray has established himself as a leading figure in the evangelical and Reformed world of the latter half of the twentieth century. Almost single-handedly through the work of the Banner of Truth Trust he has forged a return to the Calvinism and theology of the Reformers and Puritans and men like Whitefield and Spurgeon. Besides the magazine which he edited for over thirty years, his writings are numerous and he is now a respected author in his own right. Indeed, any new volume from his pen immediately creates widespread interest among the Christian public.

Murray excels in biography and his published works have included biographies of Spurgeon, A.W. Pink, John Murray, Jonathan Edwards and Dr. Martyn Lloyd Jones. This latest book is not the biography of one individual but rather an historical narrative of events centring around a number of prominent individuals. It is, nevertheless, written in the biographical style so typical of the author. It is a study of one particular theme, namely, the contrast between what the author implies is genuine God-sent *revival*, and the *revivalism* practised in the U.S.A. particularly during the middle period of the last century and associated principally with the name of Charles Grandison Finney.

There are those today who question the whole ethos of revival - see our review of the book by William Hamilton entitled *An Inquiry into the Scriptural Character of the Revival of 1859* ( Issue No.5, Jan-March 1994) of this Journal. Certainly Murray goes out of his way to evince the genuineness and purity of revivals prior to the early 1800's but whether the book proves the case for revivals being God-given outpourings of the Holy Spirit, the reader will have to judge for himself.

*Revival and Revivalism* runs to over 450 pages and is an in-depth study of its subject. The bibliography is immense (approx. 290 works are cited) and footnotes abound on nearly every page. It could be said that the book is perhaps overloaded with quotations, in the same way in which a sermon can be spoilt by excessive use of Scripture references. An appendix is devoted to a consideration of revival in Britain but it is a pity that this is so short compared with the remainder of the book. Some readers will be left wishing that a fuller treatment could have been provided of the British scene - but, clearly, this was not the end the author had in mind.

All credit must be given to the author for a well researched and absorbingly interesting analysis of religious life in 18th and 19th century America.

## Correspondence

**From Prof. Nigel F. N. Lee**  
**Queensland Presbyterian Theol. Hall,**  
**Australia.**

Dear Editor,

I was much edified by the recent issue of our British Reformed Journal (BRJ) - even though Kennedy of Dingwall would never be "forgotten" by me!

I enjoyed too, Dr. Westcott's continuing "debate" with me on early British Christianity. As he suggests, "the correspondence re. Owen should now take its end." Let me then just close that debate, by observing that even the mediaeval inscripturation of what some call "Early Britain's Christian Mythology", clusters around *nuggets* of historical truth. The historian's task today is to free those ancient nuggets from their encrusting mediaeval ore....rather than jettison the nuggets themselves!

While speaking of gold nuggets, may I also say - as one who has frequently swum across the Vaal River (BRJ No.10 p.40, footnote 5), I find it hard to imagine how one could drown there, as the water is shallow, and there are many drifts!

One needs to remember, too, (Ibid p. 41) that Baptism and the Lord's Supper are not elements of worship *every* Lord's Day! See the Westminster Assembly's *Directory for the Public Worship of God*, and my own *Quarterly Communion at Biblical Seasons Annually*, (versus sacramentalistic weekly communion).

Faithfully in Christ's Covenant,

**Prof. Nigel Lee**  
**Australia July 1995.**

### EDITOR'S RESPONSE :

It is appropriate, I think, at this juncture to thank both Prof. Lee, and Dr. Westcott for the interesting and instructive debate they carried on in the pages of our Journal. We commend them both for the high standard of debate they maintained, an example, we feel, of how Christian magnanimity can be maintained despite a radically different approach. As to the "correspondence on Owen should now take

its end", I'm afraid I've opened up another cause of controversy in this issue's **FORUM Discussion Point**! And this for the express purpose of getting readers to write in! Perhaps we shall, therefore, hear some more from our two friends, Prof. Lee and Dr. Westcott, plus any other readers who would like to contribute to the next issue's **FORUM Response**.



**From Mr. W.F. Spanner**  
**Seaford, E. SUSSEX.**

Dear Editor,

### The Free Offer of the Gospel

I have read Pastor Ronald Hanks's article on the Free Offer of the Gospel (BRJ Issue No. 8) and consider his criticism of Prof. John Murray's exposition of the Free Offer (*Collected Writings Vol 4, p.113 ff.*) misconceived. I find Professor Murray's exposition entirely Scriptural and wholly in accord with the Word of God.

Pastor Hanks is right in pointing out that by nature all men are "dead in trespasses and sins" but he fails to point out that all men have the power to make a choice and in this respect are unlike trees. There is no external compulsion for them to choose evil and their choice of evil springs solely from their sinful nature. We also have to remember that they are not without witness (Acts 14 : 17) nor without the light of conscience (John 1:9). Consider the case of Cain. The LORD made a gracious offer of acceptance when he put to Cain the rhetorical question "If thou doest well shalt thou not be accepted?" (Gen. 4 : 7). What was the LORD offering him? He was offering full acceptance by the One whom to know is life eternal. (John 17 : 3). To say that the LORD knew Cain to be a reprobate and that therefore the offer was insincere is to fall into the error of the rationalists. God deals with us as persons and not as sticks and stones and Cain was given by the LORD the full opportunity of full restoration, as this Scripture makes abundantly